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Culture (OWC): [Tonga \(FQ12\)](#)

Region: Africa

Sub Region: Southern Africa

Field Date: 1946-1947, 1948, 1950

Coverage Date: 1945-1951

Place Coverage

northeast-central Southern province, Zambia

Section Title(S)

CASE XII: PARENTAL CONTROL OF MARRIAGE • Marriage Payments

Many of these arguments are inapplicable to a marriage with the father's sister's daughter, but the Tonga classify the two types of marriage together and the banning of the one seems to imply the banning of the other. It is possible that the change reflects the increased tension between the children of brother and sister—for they now see themselves on many occasions as rivals for the wealth of the single man through whom they trace their relationship rather than as friendly joking partners.

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For various reasons then, cross-cousin marriage has fallen from favour. Some elders today refuse to permit it, even though only a classificatory relationship is involved. Furthermore, the concept of descent is being revised, so that now some people maintain that cross-cousins, like paternal parallel cousins, share the same blood. They have not yet classed such marriages as incestuous—probably too many extant marriages still fall into this category for such a step to be feasible. But they say, 'Once we thought they were good. Now we have begun to think they are wrong.'

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Marriage Payments

At the time that a marriage is negotiated, one of the elements that must be settled is the payment of the bridewealth, even though the last instalments will not be handed over for many years to come and perhaps eventually will be commuted in some fashion. The negotiation goes on, though within any locality the amount given becomes so standardized that it is possible to

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predict the general amount of each separate payment. This standardization, 
328 however, changes over the years, and for that matter so have the number
of payments.

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